# WEEK 3: COGNITIVE RESTRUCTURING - CHALLENGING DISTORTED THOUGHTS

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## The CBT Triangle: Thoughts → Feelings → Behaviors

One of the most important concepts in recovery is this:

**Your thoughts influence your feelings, which influence your behaviors.**

```
THOUGHTS
  ↓
FEELINGS
  ↓
BEHAVIORS
```

**Example:**

**Thought:** "I've already messed up today, so I might as well keep going."

**Feeling:** Hopeless, defeated, shame

**Behavior:** Continue acting out, give up on recovery

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**The good news:** If you can change your thoughts, you can change your feelings and behaviors. This is the foundation of Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT).

**The challenge:** Your automatic thoughts happen so fast that you often don't even notice them. They feel like truth, not like thoughts that can be questioned.

This week, you'll learn to:

1. **Catch** automatic thoughts as they happen
2. **Identify** which cognitive distortions are present
3. **Challenge** those thoughts with evidence
4. **Change** the thought to something more accurate and helpful

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## Common Cognitive Distortions in CSBD

Cognitive distortions are thinking errors—automatic thoughts that aren't accurate but feel true. Everyone has them, but in CSBD, certain distortions become especially powerful.

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### 1. ALL-OR-NOTHING THINKING

Seeing things in black-and-white categories with no middle ground.

**Examples:**

- "I looked at porn once, so my recovery is completely ruined."
- "If I can't be perfect, I might as well give up."
- "I'm either in recovery or I'm a complete failure."

**Reality:** Recovery is not all-or-nothing. Progress is not linear. A slip is not the same as complete relapse. There's a massive spectrum between "perfect" and "failure."

**Alternative thought:** "I slipped, but that doesn't erase my progress. I can learn from this and keep going."

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### 2. ENTITLEMENT

Believing you deserve to act out, often after stress or difficulty.

**Examples:**

- "I've had a terrible week—I deserve this."
- "I work hard, I should be able to do what I want."
- "After what she said to me, I have a right to this."

**Reality:** Stress is not permission to harm yourself. "Deserving" escape does not justify destructive behavior. You deserve healthy coping, not compulsive behavior that creates more problems.

**Alternative thought:** "I've had a hard week and I deserve relief—but I deserve relief that doesn't harm me or my relationships."

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### 3. MINIMIZATION

Downplaying the severity or impact of your behavior.

**Examples:**

- "It's just porn, it's not hurting anyone."

- "At least I'm not cheating on my wife."
- "Compared to other guys, my problem isn't that bad."
- "This isn't really a big deal."

**Reality:** If it's causing distress, relationship problems, time loss, shame, or broken promises to yourself, it IS a big deal. Comparing yourself to others doesn't change the impact on your life.

**Alternative thought:** "This behavior is affecting my life, my relationships, and my integrity. It matters."

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**4. CATASTROPHIZING**

Assuming the worst possible outcome will happen.

**Examples:**

- "I'll never be able to have a normal relationship."
- "If my partner finds out, my life is over."
- "I'm going to lose everything."
- "I'll be alone forever."

**Reality:** You're predicting a catastrophic future that hasn't happened and may not happen. You're not considering other possible outcomes or your ability to handle difficulties.

**Alternative thought:** "I don't know what the future holds. Right now, I can focus on the next right action."

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**5. MIND READING**

Assuming you know what others are thinking about you (usually negative).

**Examples:**

- "She thinks I'm disgusting."
- "Everyone can tell something's wrong with me."
- "He knows what I've been doing."
- "They're all judging me."

**Reality:** You cannot read minds. You're projecting your own shame and self-judgment onto others. Most people are too focused on their own lives to think about you as much as you imagine.

**Alternative thought:** "I don't actually know what she's thinking. I'm assuming the worst based on my own shame."

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**6. JUSTIFICATION**

Creating reasons why the behavior is acceptable or necessary.

**Examples:**

- "Everyone does this."
- "This is just how men are."
- "I can't help it—it's biology."
- "My marriage is sexless, so what choice do I have?"

**Reality:** Many men don't engage in compulsive sexual behavior. Biology creates urges, but humans have the capacity for choice. Relationship problems don't justify compulsive behavior—they require honest communication and solutions.

**Alternative thought:** "I'm trying to justify behavior that conflicts with my values. I do have other choices."

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**7. FUTURE DISCOUNTING**

Prioritizing immediate relief over long-term consequences.

**Examples:**

- "I'll deal with the consequences later."
- "Future me will figure it out."
- "I just need this right now."
- "I'll start recovery tomorrow."

**Reality:** Future you is the same person as current you. The consequences you're avoiding are real and will arrive. Temporary relief creates long-term pain.

**Alternative thought:** "This will feel good for 20 minutes and terrible for days. Future me is counting on current me to make a better choice."

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**8. SHOULD STATEMENTS**

Using rigid rules about how you "should" be, leading to shame when you don't meet unrealistic standards.

**Examples:**

- "I should be able to stop this on my own."
- "I should be stronger than this."
- "I shouldn't struggle with this at this point in my life."
- "I should be over this by now."

**Reality:** "Should" statements set you up for failure and shame. Recovery is a process, not a destination. You're human, not a machine.

**Alternative thought:** "I'm doing the best I can with the tools I have. I'm learning and growing."

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### 9. EMOTIONAL REASONING

Believing something is true because it feels true.

**Examples:**

- "I feel like a failure, so I must be a failure."
- "I feel hopeless, so there must be no hope."
- "I feel like I can't resist, so I can't resist."
- "I feel like acting out, so I should act out."

**Reality:** Feelings are not facts. Emotions are temporary states, not accurate reflections of reality. You can feel something intensely and it can still be inaccurate.

**Alternative thought:** "I feel hopeless right now, but that's a feeling, not a fact. Feelings change."

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### 10. ABSTINENCE VIOLATION EFFECT (AVE)

After one slip, deciding that recovery is completely over and continuing to act out.

**Examples:**

- "I already messed up, so I might as well keep going."
- "I've ruined everything, so what's the point?"
- "My streak is broken, so it doesn't matter now."

**Reality:** A lapse is not a relapse. One mistake doesn't erase all your progress or mean you're back to square one. What you do next matters more than the slip itself.

**Alternative thought:** "I slipped. That's disappointing, but I can stop the cycle right now and learn from this."

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## EXERCISE 1: IDENTIFYING MY COGNITIVE DISTORTIONS

Review the 10 distortions above. Which ones do you use most often?

**Rank your top 5 distortions** (1 = most frequent, 5 = fifth most frequent):

_____ All-or-Nothing Thinking

_____ Entitlement

_____ Minimization

_____ Catastrophizing

_____ Mind Reading

_____ Justification

_____ Future Discounting

_____ Should Statements

_____ Emotional Reasoning

_____ Abstinence Violation Effect

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**MY TOP 5 DISTORTIONS:**

**1.** _____

**2.** _____

**3.** _____

**4.** _____

**5.** _____

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**For each of your top 5, write an example of how you use this distortion:**

**Distortion #1:**

Example: _____

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**Distortion #2:**

Example: _____

---

**Distortion #3:**

Example: _____

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**Distortion #4:**

Example: _____

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**Distortion #5:**

Example: _____

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## Introduction to Thought Records

A **thought record** is a tool for identifying and challenging automatic thoughts in real time.

It has five columns:

1. **SITUATION:** What happened? (Just the facts, no interpretation)
2. **AUTOMATIC THOUGHT:** What went through your mind?
3. **EMOTION:** What did you feel? (Name the emotion and rate intensity 1-10)
4. **BEHAVIOR:** What did you do (or want to do)?
5. **ALTERNATIVE THOUGHT:** What's a more balanced, accurate thought?

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**HOW TO USE A THOUGHT RECORD:**

**Step 1: Catch the situation** Notice when you're triggered, upset, or experiencing an urge. Write down what's happening.

**Step 2: Identify the automatic thought** What thought went through your mind right before the emotion? This might be hard to catch at first—automatic thoughts are fast. Sometimes you'll need to work backward from the emotion.

**Step 3: Name the emotion and rate it** What are you feeling? Anxious? Angry? Ashamed? Rate the intensity 1-10.

**Step 4: Notice the behavior urge** What do you want to do? What did you do?

**Step 5: Challenge the thought**

- What's the evidence for and against this thought?
- What distortion is present?
- What would I tell a friend who had this thought?
- What's a more balanced way to look at this?

**Step 6: Create an alternative thought** Write a more accurate, balanced thought. It doesn't have to be positive—it just has to be true.

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## THOUGHT RECORD EXAMPLE

**SITUATION:** My partner asked if I'd been looking at porn again.

**AUTOMATIC THOUGHT:** "She knows. She's going to leave me. My life is over."

**EMOTION:** Panic (9/10), Shame (10/10)

**BEHAVIOR:** Lied and said no. Felt the urge to act out later to escape the shame.

**ALTERNATIVE THOUGHT:** "She asked a question. I don't know if she knows anything for sure. Even if she does, I can handle this conversation. Catastrophizing isn't helping. I can tell the truth and deal with whatever happens."

**DISTORTION IDENTIFIED:** Catastrophizing, Mind Reading

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## EXERCISE 2: THOUGHT RECORD PRACTICE

Complete three thought records this week. Use the template below for each one.

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**THOUGHT RECORD #1**

**SITUATION:** (What happened? Just the facts)

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**AUTOMATIC THOUGHT:** (What went through your mind?)

_____

_____

_____

**EMOTION:** (What did you feel? Rate intensity 1-10)

Emotion: _____ Intensity: _____/10

**BEHAVIOR:** (What did you do or want to do?)

_____

_____

**DISTORTION(S) PRESENT:** (Which distortion[s] can you identify?)

_____

_____

**ALTERNATIVE THOUGHT:** (What's a more balanced, accurate thought?)

_____

_____

_____

_____

**After generating the alternative thought, how intense is the emotion now?**

Emotion intensity: _____/10

_____

**THOUGHT RECORD #2**

**SITUATION:**

_____

_____

_____

**AUTOMATIC THOUGHT:**

_____

_____

_____

**EMOTION:**

Emotion: _____ Intensity: _____/10

**BEHAVIOR:**

_____

_____

**DISTORTION(S) PRESENT:**

_____

_____

**ALTERNATIVE THOUGHT:**

_____

_____

_____

_____

**Emotion intensity after alternative thought:** _____/10

_____

**THOUGHT RECORD #3**

**SITUATION:**

_____

_____

_____

**AUTOMATIC THOUGHT:**

_____

_____

_____

**EMOTION:**

Emotion: _____ Intensity: _____/10

**BEHAVIOR:**

_____

_____

**DISTORTION(S) PRESENT:**

_____

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**ALTERNATIVE THOUGHT:**

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**Emotion intensity after alternative thought:** _____/10

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## THE 3 C'S: CATCH IT, CHECK IT, CHANGE IT

This is a simple framework for challenging distorted thoughts in the moment.

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### 1. CATCH IT

**Notice when you're having a distorted thought.**

This is the hardest part. Automatic thoughts are automatic—they happen fast and feel like truth.

**Signs you're in distorted thinking:**

- Sudden intense emotion
- Urge to act out appears suddenly
- Feeling stuck or hopeless
- Making extreme statements ("always," "never," "everyone")
- Feeling defensive or justified

**Practice:** When you notice an intense emotion or sudden urge, pause and ask: "What thought just went through my mind?"

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### 2. CHECK IT

**Examine the thought for accuracy and distortions.**

Ask yourself:

- What's the evidence for and against this thought?
- Which cognitive distortion is this?

- Am I confusing thoughts with facts?
- Am I jumping to conclusions?
- What would I tell a friend who had this thought?

**Practice:** Use the list of cognitive distortions to identify which distortion(s) are present.

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**3. CHANGE IT**

**Generate a more balanced, accurate thought.**

This doesn't mean positive thinking or lying to yourself. It means finding a thought that is MORE ACCURATE than the distorted one.

**Ask yourself:**

- What's a more balanced way to look at this?
- What would be a more helpful thought right now?
- What's the reality of this situation?

**Practice:** Write down the alternative thought. Say it out loud. Notice if your emotion intensity decreases.

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## EXERCISE 3: THE 3 C'S IN ACTION

Practice the 3 C's with three common distorted thoughts. Fill in the blanks.

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**DISTORTED THOUGHT #1:** "I've already messed up today, so I might as well keep going."

**CATCH IT:** What emotion does this thought create?

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**CHECK IT:** What distortion is this? _____

What's the evidence against this thought?

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**CHANGE IT:** What's a more accurate thought?

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**DISTORTED THOUGHT #2:** "I'll never be able to stop this. I'm hopeless."

**CATCH IT:** What emotion does this thought create?

_____

**CHECK IT:** What distortion is this? _____

What's the evidence against this thought?

_____

_____

**CHANGE IT:** What's a more accurate thought?

_____

_____

_____

**DISTORTED THOUGHT #3:** "I deserve this after the week I've had."

**CATCH IT:** What emotion does this thought create?

_____

**CHECK IT:** What distortion is this? _____

What's the evidence against this thought?

_____

_____

**CHANGE IT:** What's a more accurate thought?

_____

_____

_____

## Common Permission-Giving Thoughts in CSBD

These are the thoughts that give you "permission" to act out. Recognizing them is critical.

**ENTITLEMENT THOUGHTS:**

- "I deserve this"
- "I've earned this"
- "After what I've been through, I have a right to this"

**MINIMIZATION THOUGHTS:**

- "It's not that bad"
- "Just this once won't hurt"
- "I'm not hurting anyone"

**HOPELESSNESS THOUGHTS:**

- "I've already messed up, might as well continue"
- "I'll never change anyway"
- "What's the point?"

**NECESSITY THOUGHTS:**

- "I need this"
- "I can't function without this"
- "I have to do this"

**DELAY THOUGHTS:**

- "I'll stop tomorrow"
- "Just one more time, then I'll quit"
- "After this last time, I'm done"

**SECRECY THOUGHTS:**

- "No one will know"
- "I can keep this hidden"
- "What they don't know won't hurt them"

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## EXERCISE 4: MY PERMISSION-GIVING THOUGHTS

**Which permission-giving thoughts do you use most often?** (Check all that apply)

- ☐ "I deserve this"
- ☐ "I've earned this"
- ☐ "It's not that bad"
- ☐ "Just this once"
- ☐ "I've already messed up"

- [ ] "I need this"
- [ ] "I can't function without this"
- [ ] "I'll stop tomorrow"
- [ ] "No one will know"
- [ ] Other: _____
- [ ] Other: _____

**My #1 most frequent permission-giving thought:**

_____

_____

**How I will challenge this thought when it appears:**

_____

_____

_____

_____

## WEEKLY DISTORTION TRACKER

This week, track which distortions you notice each day. This builds awareness of your patterns.

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| Day | Distortions I Noticed Today | Situations Where They Appeared |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | | |
| 2 | | |
| 3 | | |
| 4 | | |
| 5 | | |
| 6 | | |
| 7 | | |

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**At the end of the week:**

**Which distortion appeared most often?**

_____

**Which situations trigger distorted thinking most for me?**

_____

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**How did challenging my thoughts affect my urges or behaviors this week?**

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## DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 3

Continue your daily monitoring. This week, add a focus on automatic thoughts.

**Additional tracking:**

- What automatic thoughts preceded urges?
- Which cognitive distortions were present?
- Did you challenge any thoughts this week?

*[7 daily logs with same format as Weeks 1-2—see Appendix A for blank forms]*

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## WEEK 3 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 4, complete:

- [ ] Read all Week 3 material
- [ ] Identify your top 5 cognitive distortions
- [ ] Complete 3 thought records this week
- [ ] Practice the 3 C's with common distorted thoughts
- [ ] Identify your most common permission-giving thoughts
- [ ] Complete weekly distortion tracker
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days
- [ ] Notice and label cognitive distortions when they appear

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**Notes for Week 3:**

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**END OF WEEK 3**